FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



The author of *Midnight's Children* is in the news, and the memory of that original chiming of the clock forms our starting point for this special commemorative edition of INDIA TODAY. I might preface this by recalling that I almost belong to that generation, having been born three years before our Independence and that too in Lahore. My family went through the agony of Partition when their whole lives were uprooted. I was too young to recall the early years of free India, but I can imagine the joy of the people at being unshackled from colonial rule after 190 years and emerging as a democracy. Indians have endured tyranny of some form or the other for hundreds of years.

Therefore, the fact that we have survived for 75 years as a democracy, in however flawed a form, is cause for celebration. I regard this as one of the miracles of modern history. The sheer diversity would have made the odds seem insurmountable. The 29 states that we have today, which devolved from the British-ruled provinces and 584 princely states, speak 30 major languages and hundreds of minor ones. That's as complex as any continent. We are a Europe, so to say, and it took two major wars and another five decades for that continent to achieve some sort of union—that too with just one-third of our population. For the past 47 years that I have been in journalism, I have witnessed 12 general elections, countless state elections and a dozen prime ministers taking office, but our army has never come out on the streets and taken over the government.

If you trace an arc from Turkey to Japan, every country within that gamut has been through some kind of dictatorship or monarchy. Most African countries that came out of colonialism also descended into some form of totalitarian rule. Here in India, despite the centrifugal pull of language and ethnicity, we have not needed the iron hand of a military junta to stay together as a country. Often the more apathetic ones amongst us take this for granted—it's only when you lose your freedom that you realise how valuable it is. Think of the people voting during elections, queueing up in the rain and cold and killing heat. They intuitively know the value of their vote because it empowers them and enables them to bring about a change of government without any force. Despite all the political chaos that we see around us, India's polity is one of the most stable in the world. It is the most precious gift given to us by our freedom fighters. We need to cherish this and be truly grateful that we still have this right.

> I BELIEVE IN INDIA, AND ITS PEOPLE. THEY ARE TALENTED, ENTERPRISING AND RESILIENT. GIVEN AN ENVIRONMENT WHERE OFFICIAL-DOM IS AN ENABLER, NOT OBSTRUCTOR, THERE'S NOTHING WE CANNOT ACHIEVE

In these 75 years, India has made significant economic progress, although in fits and starts. The record of GDP growth for the first four and a half decades was dismal. They were the wasted years of the Indian economy as India's first prime minister took the socialist route, a legacy that continued till 1991. India's GDP growth rate registered an average of 3.5 per cent per annum till 1980. Derogatorily dubbed the Hindu rate of growth, it was the result of licence raj and the planned economy, which were miserable failures. It is difficult to imagine that we lived in a time of shortages where you had to wait for years to get a car, scooter or landline connection. In the 1970s, when I got my first paycheck, the maximum marginal rate of tax stood at 97.5 per cent (although I was not in that bracket). Such regressive taxation, along with other levies such as wealth tax, gift tax and inheritance tax, was probably why Indians got into the habit of generating black money. From the 1980s, growth accelerated—on an annual average of 6 per cent in the 1990s and around 5.5 per cent between 2000 and 2019. During this period, we had some mini-revolutions, which fuelled our growth.

There was, to start with, the IT boom built around outsourcing that began in the 1980s, followed by the automotive revolution that started with Maruti, and then by many foreign companies setting up shop here. Since the early 2000s, there has been amazing growth in telecom and digitisation, where India is leading the world, and the opening up of the financial sector to foreign investment. In these 75 years, India's contribution to global GDP has grown from less than half a per cent to 3.5 per cent, while the world economy has grown from $9 trillion to $95 trillion. In terms of purchasing power parity, India has become the third-largest economy in the world. Today, we are in a sweet spot. The world is looking to move its supply chains away from China. It is for India to capitalise on this opportunity.